

“I don’t think the human race will survive the next thousand years, unless we spread into space. There are too many accidents that can befall life on a single planet. But I’m an optimist. We will reach out to the stars.”

— **Stephen Hawking, theoretical physicist and cosmologist**

“The urge to explore has propelled evolution since the first water creatures reconnoitred the land. Like all living systems, cultures cannot remain static; they evolve or decline. They explore or expire... Beyond all rationales, space flight is a spiritual quest in the broadest sense, one promising a revitalisation of humanity and a rebirth of hope no less profound than the great opening out of mind and spirit at the dawn of our modern age.”

— **Buzz Aldrin, the second man to walk on the moon**

“The crossing of space ... may do much to turn men’s minds outwards and away from their present tribal squabbles. In this sense, the rocket, far from being one of the destroyers of civilisation, may provide the safety-value that is needed to preserve it.”

— **Arthur C. Clarke, science fiction author**

And of course, no speech summed up the need for exploration better than US President John F. Kennedy’s announcement of going to the moon at Rice University in 1962, an excerpt of which is presented here:

“We choose to go to the moon. We choose to go to the moon in this decade and do the other things, not because they are easy, but because they are hard, because that goal will serve to organize and measure the best of our energies and skills, because that challenge is one that we are willing to accept, one we are unwilling to postpone, and one which we intend to win.

Many years ago the great British explorer George Mallory, who was to die on Mount Everest, was asked why did he want to climb it. He said, “Because it is there.”

Well, space is there, and we’re going to climb it, and the moon and the planets are there, and new hopes for knowledge and peace are there. And, therefore, as we set sail we ask God’s blessing on the most hazardous and dangerous and greatest adventure on which man has ever embarked.” 